The Lord of Pain — Rakdos Poisoned-Gift Group Slug

Bracket 4 · 6 Game Changers · Exquisite Blood + Sanguine Bond loop · 100 cards · built 2026-08-23, lifegain pass same day · Bracket 3 variant = 4 swaps (see swap page)

Lands 34 (33 tap for mana; 10 basic incl. 4 fetches, 3 MDFC) **Mana sources** 42 (34 lands + 8 rocks; 41 actually tap — Glacial Chasm doesn't)
Cost reducers Jet + Ruby Medallion, Rakdos **Avg MV** 3.22 **Creatures** 22 **Gifts** 6 **Draw-punishers** 7
Cast/upkeep/mana punishers 5 **Amplifiers** 6 **Lifeline** 5 **Removal + wipes** 7 + 3 **Protection** 7 **Win conditions** 5
Game Changers 6 (B4) / 3 (B3)

COMMANDER (1)

1 The Lord of Pain {3}{B}{R} 5

LANDS (34)

1 Ancient Tomb {C}
1 Badlands {B}{R}
1 Blackcleave Cliffs {B}{R}
1 Blazemire Verge {B}{R}
1 Blood Crypt {B}{R}
1 Bloodsoaked Insight {B}{R}
1 Bloodstained Mire
1 Cabal Coffers {B}
1 Command Tower {B}{R}
1 Dragonskull Summit {B}{R}
1 Fell the Profane {B}
1 Foreboding Ruins {B}{R}
1 Glacial Chasm
1 Graven Cairns {B}{C}{R}
1 Haunted Ridge {B}{R}
1 Luxury Suite {B}{R}
1 Malakir Rebirth {B}
1 Marsh Flats
1 Mount Doom {B}{R}
4 Mountain {R}
1 Polluted Delta
1 Reliquary Tower {C}
1 Smoldering Marsh {B}{R}
1 Sulfurous Springs {B}{C}{R}
2 Swamp {B}
1 Tainted Peak {B}{C}{R}
1 Urborg, Tomb of Yawgmoth {B}
1 Verdant Catacombs
1 Witch's Clinic {C}
1 Wooded Foothills

RAMP & COST REDUCTION (11)

1 Arcane Signet {2} 2
1 Dark Ritual {B} 1
1 Grim Monolith {2} 2
1 Jet Medallion {2} 2
1 Mana Vault {1} 1
1 Mox Diamond {0} 0
1 Rakdos Signet {2} 2
1 Rakdos, Lord of Riots {B}{B}{R}{R} 4
1 Ruby Medallion {2} 2
1 Sol Ring {1} 1
1 Talisman of Indulgence {2} 2

CARD DRAW — YOURS (2)

1 Jeska's Will {2}{R} 3
1 Valgavoth, Harrower of Souls {2}{B}{R} 4

TUTORS (2)

1 Demonic Tutor {1}{B} 2
1 Vampiric Tutor {B} 1

PROTECTION & DEFENSE (6)

1 Deflecting Swat {2}{R} 3
1 Hexing Squelcher {1}{R} 2
1 Kaya's Ghostform {B} 1
1 Mithril Coat {3} 3
1 No Mercy {2}{B}{B} 4
1 Swiftfoot Boots {2} 2

REMOVAL (7)

1 Bedevil {B}{B}{R} 3
1 Chaos Warp {2}{R} 3
1 Deadly Rollick {3}{B} 4
1 Feed the Swarm {1}{B} 2
1 Infernal Grasp {1}{B} 2
1 Lich's Relic {B} 1
1 Rakdos Charm {B}{R} 2

BOARD WIPES (3)

1 Blasphemous Act {8}{R} 9
1 Fraying Omnipotence {3}{B}{B} 5
1 Toxic Deluge {2}{B} 3

GIFTS — THE POISONED GENEROSITY (6)

1 Descent into Avernus {2}{R} 3
1 Font of Mythos {4} 4
1 Howling Mine {2} 2
1 Seizan, Perverter of Truth {3}{B}{B} 5
1 Spiteful Visions {2}{U}{R} 4
1 Temple Bell {3} 3

DRAW PUNISHERS (6)

1 Fate Unraveler {3}{B} 4
1 Kederekt Parasite {B} 1
1 Orcish Bowmasters {1}{B} 2
1 Razorkin Needlehead {R}{R} 2
1 Sheoldred, the Apocalypse {2}{B}{B} 4
1 Underworld Dreams {B}{B}{B} 3

CAST / UPKEEP / MANA PUNISHERS (6)

1 Kaervek the Merciless {5}{B}{R} 7
1 Manabarbs {3}{R} 4
1 Mogis, God of Slaughter {2}{B}{R} 4
1 Painful Quandary {3}{B}{B} 5
1 Powerbalance {R}{R} 2
1 Vial Smasher the Fierce {1}{B}{R} 3

AMPLIFIERS (6)

1 Bloodletter of Aclazotz {1}{B}{B}{B} 4
1 Solphim, Mayhem Dominus {2}{R}{R} 4
1 Spiked Corridor {3}{R}{3}{R} 8
1 Torbran, Thane of Red Fell {1}{R}{R}{R} 4
1 Twinflame Tyrant {3}{R}{R} 5
1 Wound Reflection {5}{B} 6

LIFELINE (5)

1 Basilisk Collar {1} 1
1 Bloodthirsty Conqueror {3}{B}{B} 5
1 Exquisite Blood {4}{B} 5
1 Sanguine Bond {3}{B}{B} 5
1 Whip of Erebos {2}{B}{B} 4

WIN CONDITIONS (5)

1 Exsanguinate {X}{B}{B} 2
1 Gray Merchant of Asphodel {3}{B}{B} 5
1 Heartless Hidetsugu {3}{R}{R} 5
1 Torment of Hailfire {X}{B}{B} 2
1 Wheel of Fortune {2}{R} 3

Build history — 7 substitutions made to finalize this list

IN



Basalt Monolith {3}

Doesn't untap during your untap step. {T}: Add {C}{C}{C}. {3}: Untap this artifact.

↔

Grim Monolith {2}

Doesn't untap during your untap step. {T}: Add {C}{C}{C}{C}. {4}: Untap this artifact.



OUT

Why: BRACKET 3 SWAP. Game Changer. Basalt is the same card one mana up, with a {3} untap instead of {4}.

Bring back: Any Bracket 4 table.

IN



Imp's Mischief {1}{B}

Change the target of target spell with a single target. You lose life equal to that spell's mana value.

↔

Vampiric Tutor {B}

Search your library for a card and put it on top. Lose 2 life.



OUT

Why: BRACKET 3 SWAP. Game Changer, and B3 wants tutors sparse. The redirect behind Deflecting Swat.

Bring back: Any Bracket 4 table.

IN



Leechridden Swamp land

Swamp; enters tapped. {B},{T}: each opponent loses 1 life (needs two black permanents).

↔

Glacial Chasm land

Prevent all damage that would be dealt to you. Cumulative upkeep — pay 2 life. Sacrifice a land on entry; creatures you control can't attack; no mana.



OUT

Why: BRACKET 3 SWAP. Glacial Chasm is on the Game Changers list.

Bring back: Any Bracket 4 table.

IN



Mind Stone {2}

{T}: Add {C}. {1}, {T}, Sacrifice this artifact: Draw a card.

↔

Mana Vault {1}

Doesn't untap during your untap step. At the beginning of your upkeep, you may pay {4} to untap it. At the beginning of your draw step, if tapped, it deals 1 damage to you. {T}: Add {C}{C}{C}.



OUT

Why: BRACKET 3 SWAP. Game Changer. Mind Stone is the non-GC 2-drop that cashes in for a card late.

Bring back: Any Bracket 4 table.

IN



Shadowspear {1}

Equipped creature gets +1/+1, trample, lifelink. {1}: opponents' permanents lose hexproof and indestructible. Equip {2}.

↔

Sanguine Bond {3}{B}{B}

Whenever you gain life, target opponent loses that much life.



OUT

Why: BRACKET 3 SWAP. Bond + Exquisite Blood (or + Bloodthirsty Conqueror) is a two-card infinite; taking Bond out removes both loops. Shadowspear is a second lifelink equipment for the commander.

Bring back: Any Bracket 4 table.

IN



Swamp land

Basic.

↔

Ancient Tomb land

{T}: Add {C}{C}. Deals 2 damage to you.



OUT

Why: BRACKET 3 SWAP. Game Changer.

Bring back: Any Bracket 4 table.

IN



Thought Vessel {2}

You have no maximum hand size. {T}: Add {C}.

↔

Mox Diamond {0}

If this would enter, you may discard a land card instead. If you do, put it onto the battlefield. If you don't, put it into its owner's graveyard. {T}: Add one mana of any color.



OUT

Why: BRACKET 3 SWAP. Game Changer. Vessel is a second no-max-hand-size effect behind Reliquary Tower, which matters at 6+ draws a turn.

Bring back: Any Bracket 4 table.

Sideboard — what to bring in, and when



Archfiend of Despair {6}{B}{B}

Bring in: Second Wound Reflection for long Coffers games. Displaces Wound Reflection or runs alongside.



Bloodchief Ascension {B}

Bring in: Grindy pod — arms in 3 end steps, then 2 per card into their graveyard (14 per wheel). Displaces Seizan.



Bojuka Bog —

Bring in: Reanimator pod — a second graveyard exile behind Rakdos Charm. Enters tapped. Displaces Mana Vault.



Bolt Bend {3}{R}

Bring in: Third redirect behind Deflecting Swat; costs {R} with the commander out. Single-target spells only. Displaces Mox Diamond.



Brash Taunter {4}{R}

Bring in: Creature-heavy pod — Taunter + Blasphemous Act is 13 (×2 Solphim) to one player. Displaces Fraying Omnipotence.



Burning Inquiry {R}

Bring in: 1-mana wheel-lite: 3 draws × punishers per opponent. Displaces Fraying Omnipotence.



Chandra, Awakened Inferno {4}{R}{R}

Bring in: Enchantment-removal-heavy pod; emblems can't be answered. Displaces Manabarbs.



Court of Ambition {2}{B}{B}

Bring in: Grindy pod; 3 life or discard per upkeep, monarch baits attacks away. Displaces Manabarbs.



Imp's Mischief {1}{B}

Bring in: Combo/counter-heavy pod — second redirect, spells only, costs life = MV (already the B3 Vampiric swap). Displaces Vial Smasher.



Kardur, Doomscourge {2}{B}{R}

Bring in: Go-wide attackers; goad + drain. Displaces No Mercy.



Kefka, Dancing Mad {5}{B}{R}

Bring in: 'I cast your cards and you pay for them' finisher. Displaces Heartless Hidetsugu.



Leechridden Swamp land

Bring in: B3 tables (Glacial Chasm is a Game Changer), or when the 35th land must tap for mana. Displaces Glacial Chasm.



Lightning Greaves {2}

Bring in: You need haste+shroud more than self-targeting (Coat attach, Collar equip, Witch's Clinic). Displaces Swiftfoot Boots.



Mana Flare {2}{R}

Bring in: Table where the extra mana poisons them more than it helps them. It gives three opponents what it gives you. Displaces Dark Ritual.



Master of the Feast {1}{B}{B}

Bring in: Pure 'here, have a card' 5/5 flier. Displaces Dark Ritual.



Mindcrank {2}

Bring in: B4 only — infinite with Bloodchief Ascension (bring both) at 3 counters. Displaces Fraying Omnipotence + Seizan.



Ob Nixilis, the Hate-Twisted {3}{B}{B}

Bring in: 8th draw-punisher that is also removal. Displaces Manabarbs.



Repercussion {1}{R}{R}

Bring in: Opponents creature-heavy, you are not: Blasphemous Act = 13 × their creatures to each of them. Displaces Fraying Omnipotence.



Scrawling Crawler {3}

Bring in: Grindy pod with no amplifier in sight — its 1 life per opponent draw is life loss, which Solphim/Torbran/Torture Pit cannot multiply, so its value collapses exactly when the deck is winning. Displaces Grim Monolith.



Shadowspear {1}

Bring in: Second lifelink equipment for the commander (already the B3 Sanguine swap). Displaces No Mercy.



Stormfist Crusader {B}{R}

Bring in: Low-curve pod; 2-drop gift/ping. Displaces Seizan.



Teferi's Puzzle Box {4}

Bring in: Chaos-friendly, counter-light tables — hand+3 punished draws per player per turn; you can't hold answers past your draw step. Displaces No Mercy.



Tempting Contract {4}

Bring in: You want the Treasure gift back (bigger opposing spells → bigger Lord/Kaervek hits). Displaces Rakdos, Lord of Riots.



Wheel of Misfortune {2}{R}

Bring in: A second true wheel. Displaces Fraying Omnipotence.



Wild Evocation {5}{R}

Bring in: Chaos table — forced free cast each upkeep triggers Lord/Kaervek/Quandary. Displaces Seizan.



Withering Torment {2}{B}

Bring in: Extra enchantment answer (Leyline of Sanctity blanks the commander). Displaces Feed the Swarm.

Every amplifier is opponent-only on purpose: the gift engines are symmetric, so a Fiery Emancipation would triple Spiteful Visions' pings on YOU. Your own damage comes back: Basilisk Collar/Whip of Erebos lifelink on the pingers, Glacial Chasm prevents all damage to you. One opponent draw under Solphim + Torture Pit with six punishers = 27. Replacement ordering is the damaged player's choice (CR 616.1): (1×2)+2+2 = 6, never (1+4)×2. Full math in research/formulas.md, pilot notes in research/gameplan.md.

THE LORD OF PAIN — GAMEPLAN (FOR THE PILOT)

What the deck is

A Rakdos group-slug deck that *looks* like group hug. You hand the table extra cards, extra mana, free Treasures and a fresh hand every turn — and every one of those gifts is billed: each draw, each spell, each upkeep, each land tapped. The commander is the cashier: every player's first spell each turn deals its mana value to **a player you choose** (anyone but the caster), and nobody on the other side can gain life back.

Mulligan

Keep a 7 with 3+ lands (or 2 lands + a rock/Medallion) **and** at least one of: a draw-punisher (Kederekt Parasite, Razorkin Needlehead, Underworld Dreams, Sheoldred, Fate Unraveler, Bowmasters), a gift engine (Howling Mine, Spiteful Visions, Font, Temple Bell), or a Medallion. One early play is enough; two is a snap-keep.

The dream 7: land, land, Sol Ring or a Medallion, Kederekt Parasite or Razorkin, Spiteful Visions or Howling Mine, one removal/protection spell, anything. That curves rock → 2-drop punisher → Lord on 3 → gift on 4, and the bill starts on turn 4.

The fast-mana openers (added 2026-09-22). T1 Mana Vault off any land puts the **Lord on turn 2** (2 lands + ◇◇◇). T2 Grim Monolith gets there on 3 with your land drop still up. Mox Diamond wants a land in hand — at 34 lands that is usually fine, but don't keep a 2-lander on the strength of it. Dark Ritual is best spent on a 4-drop engine piece two turns early, not held for a finisher. All the self-damage (Vault's draw-step 1, Ancient Tomb's 2) is **erased by Glacial Chasm** while the mana still happens — CR 615.6 for the prevention, 605.3b for Tomb's mana ability resolving anyway.

Ship it if: 1 land; 5+ lands with no engine piece; or a hand that is all amplifiers/finishers (Torbran, Solphim, Wound Reflection, Torment, Hidetsugu) with no punisher — those cards do nothing until the punishers are down. Amplifiers are the *second* thing you deploy, never the first.

6-card keeps are fine with 2 lands + rock + one engine piece; this deck draws 3+ extra a turn once an engine is out, so a slightly light hand recovers.

Tutors — what to get (Demonic Tutor, Vampiric Tutor)

Ask, in order: *what is missing from [punisher + gift + protection]?* Fetch the missing third.

Board state	Get	Why
No draw-punisher down yet	**Sheoldred, the Apocalypse**	Best single card: punishes, and pays you 2 per draw (the lifeline). Second choice Spiteful Visions (gift + punish in one).
Punishers down, no gift	**Font of Mythos** (or Howling Mine if mana-tight)	Turns 1 draw a turn into 3 — triples every punisher.
Punishers + gift down, table is healthy	**Solphim, Mayhem Dominus**	Doubles everything noncombat; the first amplifier is the one that matters.
Commander keeps dying / removal-heavy pod	**Mithril Coat** (flash, indestructible) or Kaya's Ghostform	The engine's single point of failure is the Lord.
Under attack / going wide at you	**No Mercy** or **Toxic Deluge** / Blasphemous Act	Stabilise first; the engine wins the long game.
Exquisite Blood (or Conqueror) already out, any drain live	**Sanguine Bond**	Ends the game on the next point of life lost. The reverse (Bond out → get Exquisite) is the same.
A doubler is out (Solphim / Twinflame)	**Heartless Hidetsugu**	Every even life total dies, odd go to 1; add Torbran and everyone dies.
Bloodletter out, 9 mana available	**Fraying Omnipotence**	Each opponent loses their whole life total.
Punishers out, big mana turn coming	**Wheel of Fortune**	7 draws × punishers per opponent. Cast Bloodletter first.
Flooding on mana, nothing to do	**Torment of Hailfire** (with Cabal Coffers/Urborg)	X × 3 per opponent, 6 under Bloodletter.

Vampiric Tutor puts the card on top: cast it in your end step (or in response to a Teferi's Puzzle Box trigger — the normal draw happens before draw-step triggers, so a tutored card gets bottomed otherwise). Never tutor an amplifier before a punisher, and never tutor a gift before a punisher — the gift alone is pure group hug.

Sequencing

1. **T1–2:** rock / Medallion / Kederekt / Bloodchief / Razorkin. Kederekt needs a red permanent:

a Medallion-less T1 Parasite comes online with Razorkin, Spiteful, the Lord, Torbran, Solphim.

1. **T3:** The Lord under both Medallions, or (Tomb/Sol Ring) on curve at 5. Cast the commander

before the first symmetric gift if you can — the gift is only a gift once the bill exists.

1. **Order of gifts:** Spiteful Visions first (it punishes as it gives), then Howling Mine / Font /

Temple Bell once two draw-punishers are down. **Teferi's Puzzle Box last** — only with ≥2 draw-punishers out, ideally Sheoldred or Exquisite Blood too (it shuffles your own hand every turn and Spiteful pings you per draw; Sheoldred pays you 2 per draw).

1. **Amplifiers after payoffs.** Solphim/Torbran/Torture Pit with nothing on board are blanks; with

three punishers out each one roughly doubles the clock. Bloodletter is for **your** turn (wheels, Torment, Exsanguinate, Fraying Omnipotence); Wound Reflection is for theirs.

1. **Temple Bell** timing: tap it in an opponent's end step (they draw into Sheoldred/Dreams with

no main phase to use the card) or in response to a wipe.

1. **Kaervek** is the biggest single swing after the Lord — it is 5 under both Medallions. Point

its damage at creatures when a blocker matters and at faces otherwise.

Where to aim the Lord

- The trigger targets "another" player than the caster: when Alice casts, hit Bob or Carol; when

you cast, hit whoever is ahead. Use it to **keep the table even** — the deck wins long games.

- Opponents with Leyline of Sanctity / Aegis of the Gods / Shalai can't be targeted by it — kill

the enchantment (Feed the Swarm, Chaos Warp) or route damage to the others.

- Your own first spell each turn triggers it too (and Vial Smasher at a random opponent): cast a

cheap spell precombat every turn even if it is just a Signet — 2 damage is 6 under amplifiers.

Staying alive

- Exquisite Blood / Bloodthirsty Conqueror: every point the table loses comes back to you. Under

either, the symmetric pieces (Spiteful Visions, Descent, Manabarbs, Seizan, Hidetsugu) are net positive for you.

- Sheoldred +2 per card you draw; under Mine+Font that is +6 a turn.
- Basilisk Collar on the commander from the turn it lands (1 + equip 2): every trigger is life. Whip of

Erebos makes every pinger lifelink — under Whip, Heartless Hidetsugu is a net lifegain for you.

- Glacial Chasm: drop it when the table turns on you or once 3+ symmetric pieces are out; sacrifice a

tapped/colourless land to it. Pay 2, 4, 6… — let it go when the upkeep outgrows the prevention.

- Witch's Clinic: ② to give the commander lifelink for a turn if Collar is gone.
- No Mercy + a 5/5 menace blocker. The table *will* decide you are the problem around turn 5 —

hold Deflecting Swat / Mithril Coat for the commander, not for a punisher. **Note the No Mercy / Glacial Chasm anti-synergy:** under a Chasm no creature ever deals damage to you, so No Mercy never triggers (CR 615.6, 603.2g). Pick one shield per board state; don't rely on both at once.

- Exile-based graveyard hate is **Rakdos Charm** only (Bojuka Bog went pocket 2026-09-22); bring the

Bog back for a known reanimator pod.

Kill lines (in order of how often they happen)

1. **Attrition** — three punishers + Font/Mine: ~12 per opponent per turn, doubled by the first

amplifier, doubled again at end step by Wound Reflection. Most games end here by turn 8–9.

1. **Wheel turn** — Wheel of Fortune with the punishers out: 7 draws × punishers per opponent. Cast

Bloodletter first.

1. **Heartless Hidetsugu** + Solphim/Twinflame (even totals die, odd go to 1) or + Torbran as well

(everyone dies). Haste via Swiftfoot Boots.

1. **Bloodletter + Fraying Omnipotence** — each opponent loses half ×2 = all. 9 mana.
2. **Torment of Hailfire / Exsanguinate** with Cabal Coffers/Jeska's Will/Monolith mana; Gray

Merchant for 10+ each.

1. **Exquisite Blood + Sanguine Bond** (B4) — tutor the second half with Demonic/Vampiric once the

first is down and any drain is live.

What beats you

- **Enchantment wipes / Farewell** — the engine is enchantments and artifacts. Don't overextend

punishers into a known Farewell player; two punishers + one amplifier is enough.

- **Leyline of Sanctity** (you can't target them), **counterspells on the commander** (Hexing

Squelcher, Swat), **Torpor Orb-style stax** (Font/Mine don't care).

- **Aggro turning on you early** — No Mercy or Glacial Chasm (not both — see above), keep Deadly Rollick/Terminate for the biggest attacker, and remember the Lord's trigger can point the caster's own spell damage at whoever is attacking you.
- **Your own symmetric pieces** — never run a symmetric multiplier (Fiery Emancipation etc.), never a "players can't gain life" card; decisions.md explains why.

THE LORD OF PAIN — FORMULAS

All damage-replacement ordering is chosen by the **damaged opponent** (CR 616.1): they always pick the order that hurts least. Multipliers commute; additives (+2) are applied *after* a multiplier in the opponent's chosen order. So with Solphim (×2) + Torbran (+2) + Torture Pit (+2) a 1-damage ping becomes **(1 × 2) + 2 + 2 = 6**, never (1 + 4) × 2 = 10.

One opponent draw costs…

Draw-punishers on board: Underworld Dreams, Kederekt Parasite, Razorkin Needlehead, Fate Unraveler, Orcish Bowmasters (not the first draw-step draw), Spiteful Visions = 6 × 1 **damage**; Sheoldred (2) = 2 **life loss** (not multiplied by damage effects; Scrawling Crawler, the other un-multipliable point, went pocket 2026-09-22).

Board	Per draw	Draws/turn/opp under Mine+Font+Visions (+natural) = 5	+ Temple Bell + Seizan = 8
punishers only	6 + 2 = 8	40	64
+ Solphim	12 + 2 = 14	70	112
+ Solphim + Torture Pit	(1×2+2)×6 + 2 = 26	130	208
+ Torbran too (Razorkin, Visions are red)	26 + 2×2 = 30	150	240
× Wound Reflection at end step	×2	—	—

You will rarely have all seven. **Three punishers + Font + Mine is already 3 × 4 = 12 a turn per opponent** with no amplifier; two amplifiers make it lethal within a turn cycle.

The commander's trigger

Expected first-spell MV ≈ 3. Four triggers a turn cycle (each player's first spell), all aimed by me. Under Solphim + Torbran + Torture Pit: (3 × 2) + 4 = **10 per trigger**, ~40 a round, placed where it hurts most. Under Twinflame Tyrant too: 3 × 2 × 2 + 4 = 16. Kaervek adds MV again for **every** opponent spell.

Heartless Hidetsugu

Hidetsugu deals ⌊life/2⌋ to each player (me included — not doubled, every amplifier is opponent-only).

Opp life	alone	+ Solphim or Twinflame (×2)	+ Torbran (+2)	×2 and +2
40	20 → 20 left	40 → **dead**	22 → 18	min(42, 42) → **dead**
21	10 → 11 left	20 → 1 left	12 → 9	min(22, 24) → **dead**
15	7 → 8 left	14 → 1 left	9 → 6	min(16, 18) → **dead**

Rule: **a doubler kills even life totals and leaves odd ones at 1; doubler + additive kills everything at 2+ life** (a player at exactly 1 would be dealt 0, which is no damage at all — CR 120.8). Activate with Swiftfoot Boots haste the turn he lands, or hold him until a doubler is out. I take half my own life — be above 10 and have Exquisite Blood / Conqueror out if possible (each opponent's half comes back to me).

Bloodletter of Aclazotz kills

Bloodletter doubles life **loss** during my turn. "Lose half, rounded up" ×2 = all of it:

- **Fraying Omnipotence** (5 MV): every opponent loses their whole life total. 9 mana total.
- Torment of Hailfire X: each repetition is 6 not 3 (if they don't sac/discard).
- Exsanguinate X: 2X each, I gain 3X (→ Sanguine Bond for 3X more).
- Gray Merchant: 2 × devotion each.

Exquisite Blood + Sanguine Bond

Any opponent life loss → I gain that much (Exquisite) → target opponent loses that much (Bond) → repeat. The loop only needs one opponent to lose 1 life; Bond's target is re-chosen each trigger, so it kills the table one player at a time. Bloodthirsty Conqueror is a second Exquisite. The commander's "opponents can't gain life" does not touch my gain (CR 119.9). **Bracket 4 only** — see SIDEBOARD.md for the Bracket 3 derivation.

Life coming back (Collar / Whip / Chasm)

Lifelink on the commander (Basilisk Collar) gains the trigger's damage: ~4 triggers a turn cycle at 3–10 each = 12–40 life a round, more under amplifiers (lifelink reads the damage *after* replacements, CR 120.4b–c). Whip of Erebos extends that to every creature pinger; Hidetsugu under Whip hits you for ⌊L/2⌋ and gives back the three opponents' halves — net strongly positive. Glacial Chasm prevents all damage to you (not life loss: Seizan's 2 and Infernal Grasp's 2 still land) for 2·n life on your n-th upkeep — 2+4+6+8 = 20 life over four turns; sacrifice it when that outgrows what it prevents.

Manabarbs and the self-tax

Manabarbs hits every player's land taps. Me: ~5 taps a turn = 5 damage a turn, not multiplied. Opponents: ~5 taps each, ×3 = 15, **3 per tap under Torbran** (red source) = 45 a round. Mana Flare doubles what a tap yields but not the number of taps, so it sweetens the gift without raising my own bill. With Exquisite Blood out the net is +40 for me a round; under Glacial Chasm my own bill is 0.

Commander cost

3💀🔥 = 5. Jet Medallion (black spells −1) **and** Ruby Medallion (red spells −1) both apply (it is both colours) → 1💀🔥 = 3. Each recast adds 2 tax; Kaya's Ghostform returns it for 💀 instead.

Gray Merchant devotion (black pips on permanents in the list)

Lord 1 · Underworld Dreams 3 · Bloodletter 3 · Sheoldred 2 · Conqueror 2 · Sanguine Bond 2 · Painful Quandary 2 · Exquisite Blood 1 · Wound Reflection 1 · Kederekt 1 · Fate Unraveler 1 · Seizan 2 · Kaervek 1 · Valgavoth 1 · Mogis 1 · Spiteful Visions 2 (hybrid pips count) · Bloodchief 1 · Gray Merchant 2. A mid-game board of six of these is devotion 10–12: 30+ life drained across the table, 10+ gained, Sanguine Bond fires again for the gain.